STRATEGIC FREEDOM

A FIELD GUIDE FOR CLEARER DECISIONS

The Practical Strategy Playbook

Actionable communication, reputation, municipal, campaign and business tools you can use today.

INSIDE

Message frameworks • Communications checklists • Consultation tips • Campaign planning • Copy-ready worksheets

STRATEGIC FREEDOM / NORTHERN ONTARIO

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START HERE / PRACTICAL GUIDE

Start with the issue, not the channel.

A quick way to use this guide: choose the situation you face, apply one tool, and put an owner and date beside the next action.

THE 5-MINUTE DIAGNOSIS

Before you write a post, hold a meeting, or launch a campaign, answer: What needs to change? Who must understand it? What do they need to know? What evidence supports it? What action should follow?

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PUT IT TO WORK

Choose the single result that matters most this month. Write it as a verb: explain, listen, recruit, decide, repair, or grow.

Write a message people can repeat.

A useful message is not merely memorable; it helps the audience understand an issue and decide what to do next.

THE PRINCIPLE

Build every important message around one point, one reason, one proof and one next step. Use everyday language and put the main information first.

01

Lead with the outcome

Replace “We are engaging in stakeholder consultation” with “Tell us what would improve this service before the plan is finalized.”

02

Match message to audience

Residents may ask what changes for them; staff may ask how it will work; partners may ask who is responsible. Keep the central facts consistent.

03

Read it aloud and shorten it

Aim for a clear headline, one short explanatory paragraph, and a direct action. Remove jargon, inflated claims and extra adjectives.

PUT IT TO WORK

Fill in: “We are [action] because [reason]. This matters to [audience] because [benefit]. You can [next step] by [date].”

PUBLIC RELATIONS / PRACTICAL GUIDE

Earn confidence before you need it.

Reputation is built through repeated, accurate communication and how an organization responds when questions arise.

THE PRINCIPLE

Create a trust file: confirmed facts, relevant documents, decision owners, unanswered questions, and a short public explanation that can be updated.

01

Prepare a basic media kit

Keep one accurate organization description, approved spokesperson details, contact method, current fact sheet and high-resolution logo together.

02

Separate fact from interpretation

Mark statements as confirmed, estimated, proposed, or still under review. Never dress an aspiration as a result.

03

Close the feedback loop

If you request input, explain what you heard, what will change, what will not change, and why. Silence after consultation erodes trust.

PUT IT TO WORK

Build a one-page issues log with: question, verified answer, evidence source, spokesperson, follow-up date, and publication status.

SENSITIVE ISSUES / PRACTICAL GUIDE

Respond to a difficult issue with discipline.

Use this sequence for service disruptions, contentious proposals, complaints, or fast-moving allegations.

THE PRINCIPLE

A fast response is useful only when it is accurate. Confirm the facts, protect people, and identify the next update before trying to win an argument.

01

First 30 minutes: verify and assign

Identify what is known, what is uncertain, who has authority to speak, and whether privacy, safety, or legal concerns limit disclosure.

02

First public response: be clear

Acknowledge the issue, state confirmed facts, explain immediate steps, and provide a realistic time for the next update.

03

Afterward: document and improve

Keep a timeline of decisions and statements. Review how quickly people found accurate information and whether follow-up commitments were met.

PUT IT TO WORK

Use this holding statement: “We are aware of [issue]. We have confirmed [fact]. We are [action]. We will share our next update [time/channel].”

Design consultation around decisions.

A productive public meeting is more than an open microphone: it shows what is on the table and how input will be used.

THE PRINCIPLE

Start by defining the decision, decision-maker, constraints and genuine points of choice. Ask for input only where it can meaningfully inform the outcome.

01

Publish a one-page issue brief

Explain the problem, options, trade-offs, costs or resource implications, timeline, and which body will make the decision.

02

Use more than one participation channel

Pair meetings with a plain-language summary, accessible online response option, and outreach to people who may not attend in person.

03

Report back in a traceable way

Sort input by theme, summarize competing views fairly, and show how each theme influenced the decision or why it did not.

PUT IT TO WORK

Before announcing a meeting, finish this sentence: “Your input will help us decide [specific matter] by [date].”

Build a credible local campaign message.

For a candidate or volunteer team, consistency and compliance matter as much as visual appeal.

THE PRINCIPLE

Focus on three locally relevant priorities; for each one, state a practical objective, a credible first step and how voters can learn more.

01

Listen before producing materials

Record recurring questions in neighbourhood conversations, meetings and candidate events. Use the patterns to improve issue pages and responses.

02

Keep the core facts consistent

Use the same candidate description, issue position, call to action and contact information across your website, leaflets and public appearances.

03

Check the rules before publishing

Review Ontario’s current municipal candidate guide and local clerk guidance for signs, campaign identification, spending and permitted use of information.

PUT IT TO WORK

For every priority prepare: Problem → Practical step → Who decides → Trade-off → How residents can hold you accountable.

BUSINESS STRATEGY / PRACTICAL GUIDE

Explain value without sounding generic.

People understand a service faster when they can see the audience, problem, method and practical outcome.

THE PRINCIPLE

A clear positioning statement identifies who you serve, the issue you solve, what makes your approach useful and how you demonstrate value.

01

Replace vague claims with specifics

Instead of “innovative, customer-centric solutions,” explain the problem you help solve and name a typical deliverable.

02

Show a low-friction first step

Offer a short discovery call, checklist or diagnostic. Say what a prospective client will leave with—without promising a result you cannot guarantee.

03

Use believable evidence

Explain your method, relevant experience, sample scope and process. Avoid invented testimonials, inflated client numbers or unsupported rankings.

PUT IT TO WORK

Try: “We help [audience] address [problem] through [approach], so they can [practical outcome].” Test the sentence with someone outside your field.

WEB AND SOCIAL / PRACTICAL GUIDE

Make your information easy to use on a phone.

A concise, accessible page often serves readers better than a visually busy one.

THE PRINCIPLE

Prioritize the reader's next action. Responsive design changes layout with available space; it should not hide important content on mobile.

01

Write for scanning

Use descriptive headings, short paragraphs, informative link text and a visible primary action near the top.

02

Design for access

Maintain readable contrast, keyboard access, meaningful image alternatives and usable touch targets. Respect reduced-motion preferences.

03

Measure actions, not vanity metrics

Track guide downloads, completed inquiries, event attendance or useful follow-up. Review what content actually helps a visitor complete a task.

PUT IT TO WORK

Use the 20-second test on a phone: Can a new visitor say what you offer, who it helps and what to do next—without zooming?

Worksheet 01: Message brief

Copy this page before writing a press release, speech, project update, social post or business pitch.

AUDIENCE

Who is the message for, and what do they already believe?

DESIRED ACTION

What should someone think, do or decide afterward?

SINGLE MAIN POINT

What is the one sentence they should remember?

REASONS AND EVIDENCE

What two verified facts support the point?

QUESTIONS AND OBJECTIONS

What is the strongest fair question someone might ask?

RESPONSE AND NEXT STEP

Where will they find more detail and what happens next?

REVIEW: Has every factual claim been checked by someone responsible for it?

Worksheet 02: Stakeholder map

Use this simple matrix before a consultation, announcement, campaign launch or reputation response.

Group / audience	What matters to them?	Best way to hear from them
Residents	Costs, service effects, fairness	Meetings, brief surveys, direct contact
Staff / volunteers	Timing, capacity, role clarity	Briefings, small-group sessions
Partners / media	Credible facts and access	Fact sheets, planned updates
Other stakeholders	_____	_____

THE ESSENTIAL FOLLOW-UP

After engaging any group, record the date, what was heard, who owns the response, when an update will be shared, and where the decision will be documented.

TIP: Do not treat a loud voice as proof of broad support. Look for missing perspectives.

WORK PLAN / PRACTICAL GUIDE

A 30-day action plan

A short working cycle you can repeat for a business, campaign, municipal issue or advocacy project.

WEEK 1

Define

Write the goal, audiences, risks and a one-sentence message. Confirm factual sources.

WEEK 2

Build

Prepare the brief, web page, speaking notes, Q&A; and accessible materials.

WEEK 3

Engage

Publish or share; hear from affected people; log questions and corrections.

WEEK 4

Review

Report back, check results, document decisions, and revise the next plan.

THREE METRICS TO REVIEW

1. Did the intended audience see the information? 2. Did it understand the decision or offer? 3. Did it take the appropriate next step?

Further reading and guardrails

Useful primary sources for clear communications, accessibility and Ontario municipal campaign compliance.

Canada.ca Content Style Guide

Plain language, audience needs, message structure

Accessibility Standards Canada – Plain Language

Clear wording, structure and document design

Ontario – Accessible information

How to provide accessible information and communication supports

Ontario – 2026 municipal candidates' guide

Current candidate rules, finance and campaigning; verify with your municipal clerk

W3C Web Accessibility Initiative

Web contrast, resizing and reduced motion

MDN – Responsive web design

Media queries, flexible layouts and interaction modes

Important: This is a general educational guide, not legal advice. Election requirements can change and local rules differ. Confirm applicable requirements with the municipal clerk and current official guidance.